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You Can Always Begin Again

Today's Reading: John 18:25-27

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Peter again denied it, and at once the rooster crowed."

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Back when Jesus had washed Peter's feet, he predicted that Peter would deny him three times before the rooster finished crowing. It would be a moment of intense shame for Peter.

That prediction came true. As Peter stood in the high priest's courtyard, he denied knowing the Lord—three times. The final denial was spoken to one of Malchus's relatives. (Malchus was the one whose ear Peter had cut off in the garden of Gethsemane.) Then the rooster crowed.

There were times when Peter was impetuously courageous. For example, when Jesus called Peter to become a follower, he immediately dropped his nets and did so. Later, during a storm, he was the only disciple to jump out of the boat and walk on water toward Jesus. And the night before the Lord went to the cross, Peter boastfully proclaimed he'd be willing to die for him.

But Peter also had times of embarrassing cowardice. When he faced his own crucible in the courtyard, he denied he knew Jesus. In the Lord's hour of greatest need, Peter failed him.

In fact, Peter did exactly what Judas had done. He betrayed Jesus. But Peter returned to Jesus. He experienced Jesus' gracious forgiveness. He repented and was restored to fellowship and friendship with Jesus.

Godly sorrow always leads to repentance. That was not the case for Judas. He felt sorrow, but was too proud to ask for forgiveness. Jesus would have immediately given it to him. Even at the last supper, the Lord purposely seated Judas to his left—the position of honor. Up till the last moment, Jesus yearned for him to repent. But Judas stubbornly refused.

The Savior will not force repentance on anyone. Not even the city of Jerusalem, which he had wanted to gather under his wings as a mother hen does her brood. But she refused.

Godly sorrow leads to repentance. That is the deep feeling of regret that wants to change the behavior that initially broke the Father's heart. It changes life's trajectory and moves in a direction away from sin. It receives grace that restores a life broken by sin. It rescues those with a crushed spirit.

Jesus will never reject a contrite and repentant heart. He entered this world to save sinners. He is gracious and merciful. If you return to him, you will live. He will never turn his face from you if you return to him.

Jesus loves to give second chances. Just look at Peter.

Jesus restored Peter with his grace and made him a rock in his kingdom.

Let him do so with you as well.

[from "Hearing the Voice of God" by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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